CHAPTER 8

PEASANTS ZAMINDARS AND THE STATE

CHAPTER ESSENCE AT A GLANCE:
Master agrarian relations in the Mughal Empire (16th-17th centuries): rural community structure (panchayat, muqaddam), cash crops (jins-i kamil), the Zamindari hierarchy, and Abul Fazl's Ain-i Akbari.

4 CORE PRINCIPLES TO UNDERSTAND FIRST

• **Mughal Peasant Classification:** Rural cultivators classified into: Khud-kasht (residents owning ancestral land in their own village) and Pahi-kasht (non-resident tenant farmers cultivating land in other villages on contract).

• **Village Panchayat and Jati Autonomy:** The village Panchayat was headed by the Muqaddam (mandal); settled disputes, ensured caste norms, maintained communal welfare funds, and mediated with state revenue officials.

• **Monetization and High-Value Crops:** Agriculture expanded beyond subsistence grain; the state actively incentivized cash crops (jins-i kamil: cotton, sugarcane, indigo, oilseeds) to maximize cash land revenue collections.

• **Abul Fazl's Ain-i Akbari Synthesis:** Third book of the Akbar Nama; compiled by Abul Fazl (1598) across five daftars (Manzil-abadi, Sipah-abadi, Mulk-abadi); provided statistical records of agrarian crops, prices, yields, and imperial regulations.

ESSENTIAL HISTORICAL CHRONOLOGIES & THEMES

$$\text{Mughal Peasantry} \Longleftrightarrow \text{Khud-kasht (Resident Landowners)} \longleftrightarrow \text{Pahi-kasht (Contract Tenants)}$$

Dual Operational Status of 17th Century Indian Cultivators

$$\text{Jins-i Kamil (Perfect Cash Crops)} \rightarrow \text{Cotton} + \text{Sugarcane} + \text{Indigo} + \text{Oilseeds}$$

Imperial Commercial Crop Diversification Portfolio

$$\text{Ain-i Akbari Taxonomy} \Longleftrightarrow \text{Manzil-abadi (Household)} + \text{Sipah-abadi (Military)} + \text{Mulk-abadi (Revenue/Empire)}$$

Three Primary Daftars of Abul Fazl's Statistical Gazetteer

$$\text{Zamindari Hierarchy} \Longleftrightarrow \text{Milkiyat (Personal Lands)} + \text{Revenue Intermediation} + \text{Fortified Garrisons}$$

Landed Aristocratic Apparatus in Mughal Rural Economy

CRUCIAL EXAM PRECAUTIONS & VALUATION RUBRIC SECRETS

• **Alert:** Milkiyat was the personal private land of the Zamindar cultivated for his own benefit by hired labourers or bonded tenants.

• **Alert:** The Ain-i Akbari was not written in isolation; it was the statistical and administrative appendix to the third volume of the Akbar Nama.

• **Alert:** Women in rural artisan and peasant households played an indispensable economic role in tilling, weeding, spinning yarn, and pottery shaping.

HIGH-YIELD CENTUM QUESTIONS & STEP-BY-STEP EXPLANATIONS

1. Distinguish between Khud-kasht and Pahi-kasht peasants in the Mughal countryside. [Score: 3 Marks]

Answer & Key Valuation Steps:

• **Khud-kasht:** Residents of the village in which they held their own land and agricultural implements; passed holdings hereditarily from father to son. **[1.5 Marks]**

• **Pahi-kasht:** Non-resident contractual cultivators who farmed land in neighboring villages either by choice (better terms of revenue) or out of economic distress after famines. **[1.5 Marks]**

2. Describe the composition, functions, and financial resources of the Village Panchayat in Mughal India. [Score: 4 Marks]

Answer & Key Valuation Steps:

• **Composition:** An assembly of village elders, representing major caste households with hereditary property rights, headed by a headman called Muqaddam or Mandal. **[1 Mark]**

• **Functions:** Maintained law and order, settled property boundaries, regulated community morality, and ensured that caste boundaries were respected within the village. **[1.5 Marks]**

• **Financial Resources:** Financed through a common village fund (kheda-kharcha) contributed by individual villagers, used for hosting visiting state officials and building irrigation dykes. **[1.5 Marks]**

3. What was meant by 'Jins-i Kamil'? Why did the Mughal state encourage its cultivation? [Score: 3 Marks]

Answer & Key Valuation Steps:

• **Meaning:** Literally translates to 'perfect crops' in Persian, referring to high-value commercial cash crops like cotton, sugarcane, indigo, and oilseeds. **[1.5 Marks]**

• **Reason for Encouragement:** Cash crops generated substantially higher land revenue and cash taxes for the imperial treasury compared to subsistence grain crops. **[1.5 Marks]**

4. Explain the significance and structure of Abul Fazl's 'Ain-i Akbari'. [Score: 4 Marks]

Answer & Key Valuation Steps:

• **Significance:** Completed in 1598 by Akbar's court historian Abul Fazl; represents a landmark quantitative statistical gazetteer of the Mughal administration. **[1 Mark]**

• **1. Manzil-abadi:** Concerned with the imperial household, royal palace establishment, and minting of coinage. **[1 Mark]**

• **2. Sipah-abadi:** Covered military organization, civil administration, imperial mansabdars, and biographies of nobles. **[1 Mark]**

• **3. Mulk-abadi:** The fiscal core providing quantitative agricultural statistics, revenue rates (dastur), crop yields, and provincial gazetteer data across subas. **[1 Mark]**

5. State two sources of economic power possessed by Zamindars in the Mughal agrarian system. [Score: 2 Marks]

Answer & Key Valuation Steps:

• **Source 1:** Extensive personal private landed estates (Milkiyat) cultivated for their profit, and the legal right to collect revenue on behalf of the state for a share. **[1 Mark]**

• **Source 2:** Possession of fortified brick and mud fortresses (qilas) and private armed contingents of cavalry and infantry. **[1 Mark]**

6. Describe the economic contribution of women in the Mughal agrarian household. [Score: 2 Marks]

Answer & Key Valuation Steps:

• **Contribution:** Women worked shoulder-to-shoulder with men in the fields (sowing, weeding, harvesting, winnowing) and dominated craft activities like spinning yarn and decorating pottery. **[2 Marks]**